PR Campaign Proposal: Beyond the Court - Wolves for Youth

Submitted by: Emily Hamling
Role: Communications and Public Relations Assistant
Organization: Iowa Wolves
Nonprofit Partner: Up2Us Sports
Class: BAIS:3178

Proposal Summary

Introduction

Up2Us Sports is a national non-profit organization that aims to bring experienced coaches into schools to assist students' emotional and social growth. Its mission is to leverage sports' power to enrich the lives of young people. This proposal proposes a strategic partnership between Up2Us Sports and the Iowa Wolves, the NBA G League team of the Minnesota Timberwolves, to partner on launching a PR campaign that will propel social responsibility goals and achieve long-term community impact.

This alliance will further allow the Iowa Wolves to develop community involvement, particularly with at-risk youth, consistent with their mission of inspiring and empowering through sports. The effort secures the team's brand as a socially responsible entity and optimizes fan loyalty by underscoring tangible local investment. For Up2Us Sports, the partnership brings more facility availability, broader public exposure, and additional funding and volunteer support in the Des Moines market.

Overview of the PR Campaign

The proposed PR campaign, "Beyond the Court: Wolves for Youth," will sponsor 10 Up2Us Sports coach-mentors in Des Moines. The campaign will utilize integrated messaging through social media, local media outlets, and Wolves home games to create awareness, strengthen community relations, and showcase the power of sports mentorship.

Research Insights

- Youth with mentors are 55% more likely to attend college and 78% more likely to volunteer than those without mentors (MENTOR, 2023).
- One in three children quits sports by age 11 due to high costs and lack of access (Aspen Institute, 2019).
- Over 3,800 coaches have been trained and more than 100,000 youth have been served by Up2Us Sports across the country, but Des Moines remains an underserved market for their model (Up2Us Sports, 2024).

These facts point to the worth of making youth sports and mentorship more accessible, especially in mid-sized metro markets like Des Moines. The Wolves' strong online presence, name recognition, and affinity with local families make them an ideal PR enhancer for Up2Us.

Goals and Objectives

1. Enhance exposure of the Iowa Wolves and Up2Us alliance to achieve 100,000+ campaign views on digital media by June 30, 2025.
2. Fund and assign 10 coach-mentors in Des Moines-area schools or recreation centers by August 2025.
3. Improve social media engagement (likes, shares, comments) 20% higher than baseline on Iowa Wolves social media posts promoting the campaign by June 30, 2025.

Target Publics

- Parents of K–12 youth in Des Moines
- Teachers, youth leaders, and school administrators
- Current Wolves fans and ticket holders
- Local business sponsors and CSR departments

Key Messages

- "Mentorship through basketball builds brighter futures."
- "The Wolves are committed to youth, on and off the court."
- "Every coach trained = one more child empowered."

Channels, Strategies & Tactics

Owned Channels:

- Iowa Wolves social media (Instagram, TikTok, X): Weekly video spotlights of coaches and kids, using hashtag #WolvesForYouth
- Wolves website: Dedicated landing page with campaign progress bar and donation link
- In-game promotions: Halftime videos and printed coach features in game programs

Earned Media:

- Press release and media pitches to the Des Moines Register and WHO 13
- Feature articles on coaches' impact stories

Direct Contact:

- Player visits to local schools and youth centers
- Joint youth basketball clinic with Wolves and Up2Us mentors

Media/Influencer Activation

- Keith Murphy, WHO 13 Sports Director: High visibility and local trust
- @IowaEvents (Instagram): Strong reach among families and Gen Z
- Des Moines Register: Traditional media credibility and wide readership

These contacts can amplify the campaign's reach and give it resonance in the Des Moines market.

Execution Calendar & Deliverables

A full two-week campaign calendar, including a school visit, press launch, and social rollout, appears in the Appendix. Deliverables include an infographic and a sample Instagram post with a branded caption.

Evaluation Metrics

- Digital Reach: Track total impressions, views, and hashtag usage
- Engagement Growth: Measure increases in likes, shares, and comments
- Media Coverage: Count articles placed, calculate earned media value
- Impact Tracking: Number of coaches funded and kids mentored

References (APA Style)

Aspen Institute. (2019). State of play: Trends and developments in youth sports. https://www.aspeninstitute.org/publications/state-of-play-2019-trends-and-developments/

MENTOR. (2023). The mentoring effect: Young people's perspectives on the outcomes and availability of mentoring. https://www.mentoring.org/resource/the-mentoring-effect/

Up2Us Sports. (2024). About Us. https://www.up2us.org/about-coach

Appendix – Communication Deliverables

Section A: Infographic

This infographic was created to visually summarize the main goals, facts, and scope of the Iowa Wolves' sponsorship with Up2Us Sports. It is designed to be easily shared on social media, sent out as an e-newsletter, and as a print or electronic flyer at community events. The graphic highlights the campaign's mission, most significant stakeholder benefits, and a call to action to further the cause. It reinforces the primary message that sport-based mentorship can transform lives.

Section B: Social Media Post

Platform: Instagram

Visual: The image features an Up2Us Sports coach leading a group of elementary and middle school-aged children through basketball drills on a professional indoor court. The Iowa Wolves and Up2Us Sports logos appear in the upper-left corner. At the bottom, a stylized search bar reads:

"How can I help the youth?" - framing the visual call to action.

Caption:

Mentorship changes everything.

The Iowa Wolves are proud to partner with @Up2UsSports to launch #WolvesForYouth, a campaign to fund and train 10 sports mentors for kids in Des Moines.

These coaches will help over 400 local youth build confidence, leadership skills, and a lifelong love for the game.

Want to make a difference?

- ✓ Share this post
- ✓ Donate to support a coach
- ✓ Learn more at iowawolves.com/wolvesforyouth

#BeyondTheCourt #WolvesForYouth #MentorshipMatters #IowaWolves #Up2UsSports #DesMoinesYouth

Section C: Two-Week Campaign Calendar

This campaign calendar outlines promotional activities and communications tactics for the first two weeks of the "Wolves for Youth" PR campaign. It includes digital and in-person strategies such as social media rollouts, media outreach, a direct contact school visit, and in-game activations. Each activity is planned with specific platforms, responsibilities, and deliverables, all designed to raise awareness, drive engagement, and mobilize community support.

Two-Week Campaign Calendar: "Beyond the Court: Wolves for Youth"

Date	Activity	Location / Platform	Lead / Involved	Deliverables
Mon, June 3	Campaign launch teaser post	Instagram, X, Facebook	Wolves PR & Social Team	Image + caption, hashtag #WolvesForYouth
Tue, June 4	Press release sent to local media	Email + Wolves media site	Comms & PR Assistant	Press release (PDF)
Wed, June 5	Coach spotlight video #1 (Up2Us mentor profile)	Instagram Reels + TikTok	Video team + Coach	Short-form video (60 sec)
Fri, June 7	Direct contact initiative: Wolves players visit local school + media invited	Lincoln Middle School	PR Assistant, players, media	Photo opps, earned media coverage
Mon, June 10	Coach spotlight video #2 (mentee story)	Instagram + YouTube Shorts	Coach + mentee	Short-form video (60 sec)
Wed, June 12	Midpoint update + infographic post	Facebook, X, Instagram	Comms team	Infographic showing impact so far
Fri, June 14	Halftime "Mentor Moment" feature + live social clip	Wells Fargo Arena (Game Day)	Game Ops, Up2Us Coach & Wolves	Game program mention + jumbotron feature
Sun, June 16	Partner spotlight: Up2Us Sports overview	Wolves' website blog + LinkedIn	PR Assistant	Long-form blog + sponsor tag